Indira Gandhi led India in military victory against Pakistan and adopted a more robust posture in fighting various insurgencies within the country. Building Indian military might alongside its claim to higher moral ground in the cold war became essential elements of Indian foreign policy. Indira's assassination in October 1984 resulted in the passing of the leadership mantle to Nehru's grandson and Indira's son Rajiv Gandhi, who was chosen prime minister at the age of forty-four with little previous political experience. The third prime minister from the Nehru-Gandhi family left his own mark on India's external relations at a time when the cold war was in its last stages.

Rajiv had entered politics in 1980, after the death of his younger brother, and Indira's heir presumptive, Sanjay Gandhi. A former airline pilot, Rajiv soon became general secretary of the Congress party and was one of his mother's close aides for the next four years. Dixit argues that even though Rajiv 'came to power without any discernible or direct experience or knowledge of politics', he 'could legitimately claim absorption of general information and experience' from his grandfather and mother.[95] In her book on Rajiv's years in power, American writer Kathleen Healy made a similar point. She wrote that Rajiv 'lived with and learned from Nehru, his father Feroze Gandhi and his mother Indira Gandhi all of whom lived and suffered for India. Rajiv's personal knowledge of history has been and is a lived experience.' [96]

Before being thrust into the office of prime minister, Rajiv had overseen the functioning of the foreign affairs cell of the Congress party and had travelled around the world often with his mother. As prime minister, Rajiv's views on foreign policy reflected Nehru's idealistic and moralistic streak combined with a streak of pragmatism inherited from Indira.

In a recent book Srinath Raghavan argues that the 'incipient shift in foreign policy' under Rajiv 'stemmed from a conjunction of external and internal factors'. [97] Rajiv 'recognized the importance of foreign policy in